

Making a better Ranji Trophy schedule the need of the hour

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Workload management has emerged as a ubiquitous term in Indian cricket, perhaps even surpassing the use of phrases like "following processes" or "sticking to the basics." Once an Indian cricketer enters the national team or becomes a regular fixture in the Indian Premier League (IPL), these two words swiftly become part of their lexicon. Even the custodian of the game in India, the Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI), has adopted this terminology in its sporadic official statements regarding player availability.

The support staff of the national cricket team emphasises the importance of managing the workload of players due to the hectic cricket schedule. However, this same approach seems to be disregarded when it comes to domestic cricket.

Although most cricketers start their journey by playing in the Ranji Trophy, they tend to overlook the mismanagement of workload in the premier First-Class championship.

Naturally, Shardul Thakur, a member of India's ODI World Cup squad who played a key role in the knockouts to help Mumbai regain

the trophy, voicing concerns about the stretched Ranji schedule was a welcomed relief for the domestic cricket community. He didn't hold back in expressing his dissatisfaction with the tightly packed 10 consecutive rounds of Ranji matches, with only three days' respite in between games. "I think next year they will have to have a look at it and give more breaks. **The schedule is becoming tighter and tighter. If the boys keep playing like this for two more seasons, there will be a lot of injuries across the country,**" Thakur remarked during a media interaction after scoring his maiden First-Class hundred in Mumbai's Ranji semifinal against Tamil Nadu. The following day, when Thakur reiterated his sentiments during the post-match presentation of the Ranji semifinal, all his Mumbai teammates applauded in agreement. Some of the disappointed Tamil Nadu players, despite the visible dismay of a crushing innings defeat, also joined in the applause.

Over the past decade, the IPL has taken centre stage in the global cricket calendar, often at the expense of domestic cricket. Issues like starting the season during the monsoon and holding important matches in foggy regions have plagued domestic cricket. Additionally, the focus on the Syed

Mushtaq Ali T20 Trophy (SMAT) before the IPL player auction has further marginalised the Ranji Trophy. The most recent edition of the Ranji Trophy, the 89th, was crammed into a tight 70-day window, with teams constantly travelling between matches. This hectic schedule left finalists Mumbai and Vidarbha fatigued. Players like Mohit Avasthi from Mumbai and the Vidarbha pace trio were visibly worn out, with little time to recover between matches. Contrastingly, the tournament was more spread out in the 2013-14 season — a maximum of 47 match days — allowing teams adequate rest before crucial games. Overall, the Ranji Trophy has undergone significant changes, transitioning from a 99-day tournament with breaks to a tightly packed schedule of consecutive matches. **In Australia's red-ball domestic tournament, the Sheffield Shield, the six teams play 10 league stage fixtures each, with the top two contesting the final. The gap between consecutive league stage fixtures ranges from 6-11 days.**

England, on the other hand, has 10 teams in the County Championship Division One. Each team plays 14 games, with the table-topper crowned the Division One champion. There is a gap of three days between each County